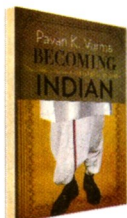


Colonial COMPLEX

Varma rages against everything English in this mocktail of historical scholarship



BECOMING INDIAN: THE UNFINISHED REVOLUTION OF CULTURE AND IDENTITY
by PAVAN K. VARMA
Allen Lane
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| By Chandan Mitra |

Pavan Varma, celebrity diplomat, erudite scholar, articulate speaker, culture aficionado, architecture connoisseur, prolific writer and last but not the least fellow Stephanian and friend, says he took four years to write this latest of his numerous well-researched monographs. He could have accomplished it in less because somewhere down the narrative, he appears to have lost the plot. Unfortunately, worse, he slid down the slippery path to pen a mocktail of historical scholarship and anecdotal flippancy. Given his masterly command of English prose, however, the resultant compilation is still eminently readable, but I am sure that his innumerable fans would be somewhat perplexed by the apparent purposelessness of the volume.

I was rather taken aback by Varma's shrill diatribe against the English language (of which he is a splendid craftsman) and everything colonial, at the outset of the book. Of course, to his credit he does not spare even his ancestors, referring to the incongruity of his father being selected for the coveted ICS despite his background as a child born and brought up in Ghazipur, a back-of-the-beyond town near Varanasi, where Lord Cornwallis breathed his last.

It's significant that Varma's father joined the ICS in 1941 just a year before this region erupted in incandescent rage in response to Gandhiji's Quit India call.

The neighbouring district of Ballia declared "independence" with local Congress leader Chittu Pandey being declared "president" of the "republic of Ballia" for seven days in August-September 1942. The British chose to transfer power to India just five years after that. The "illusion of permanence" that drove British policy till the early 1940s evaporated in a jiffy. Even New Delhi, handcrafted by British

imperial authority and executed by Edwin Lutyens, whom Varma holds in disdainful wrath, passed on to Indian hands barely 30 years after it was built.

What I found somewhat baffling was Varma's exhaustive and, at times laboured, chronicling of fairly commonplace accounts of the racial prejudices of early English rulers of our country. That Thomas Babington Macaulay held Hindu scholarship in utmost contempt and believed that only the creation of a class of Indians sculpted in their colonial master's image would help perpetuate British rule, is too well known to bear detailed recapitulation. Arguably, some of the comments penned by Macaulay, meticulously quoted by Varma, are relatively new, but they are mere add-ons to existing knowledge.

The author, interestingly, delves into the schizophrenic persona of the revered father of the Bengal Renaissance, Raja Ram Mohun Roy, pointing out how a distinguished scholar of

Hindu philosophy and Persian texts metamorphosed into a meek petitioner and imitator of European scholarship and English accoutrements.

Many might regard this as iconoclasm, but frankly I too did not see the purpose of the denigration.

Personalities are the products of their time, and it is not surprising that the distinguished Brahmin zamindar decided that the adoption of British linguistic and cultural values were necessary for society's advancement. That does not make the Raja a lesser man, just as Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's evocative appreciation of British rule as a panacea for Muslim depredation in the later Mughal centuries does not make the author of Vande Mataram less of a patriot.

But some significant points can be derived from Varma's writing.



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